

Teaching Statement

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Knowledge is dynamic—constantly evolving as new discoveries challenge established beliefs. My teaching philosophy is grounded in this reality: my goal is not to tell students *what* to think, but to help them learn *how* to think. I see myself as a craftsman of intellectual tools—a master carpenter teaching the correct use of a hammer, not prescribing how the chair must be built. Once students learn to use the hammer well, they can build with creativity and confidence.

Teaching Experience

Across my appointments at the Lahore University of Management Sciences (LUMS) and as Visiting Assistant Professor at Iowa State University, I have taught a broad range of undergraduate and graduate courses—*Microeconomic Theory* (graduate), *Public Finance*, *Intermediate and Principles of Microeconomics*, *Game Theory*, *Development Economics*, *Behavioral Economics*, and *Issues in Economic Policy*. These experiences have equipped me to teach both theory- and policy-oriented courses at multiple levels, from a graduate theory sequence at Iowa State to field- and evidence-driven electives at LUMS.

From Course to Book: *Public Economics for Developing Countries*

The course I have invested most in is *Public Finance*, which I have taught at LUMS since 2020. Teaching it made a gap obvious: the standard textbooks are excellent, but their home ground is a state that observes most incomes, can implement what it decides, and can take a working relationship with its citizens for granted—none of which holds where my students live. The modern empirical literature on taxation and public spending in developing countries is now mature enough to support a coherent undergraduate treatment, so I began writing one. *Public Economics for Developing Countries* is organized around the questions a developing-country state faces—what to provide, whom to support, what to tax, how to collect—under three constraints that run through every chapter: most incomes are unobserved, administrative capacity is scarce, and the citizen–state relationship is itself at stake. Each chapter pairs the theory with an *Evidence Spotlight* on a landmark study, a *Pakistan in Focus* box drawn where possible from my own field research, a *Working with Data* exercise built on published replication packages, and a graded bank of problems.

The book is being written in the classroom rather than in advance. In Fall 2026, my *Public Finance* students read the draft chapters as their course text. Every week, they submit a one-page memo—the chapter’s core idea in their own words, one attempted problem, their “muddiest point,” and a discussion starter—and class begins from those memos; the muddiest points go straight into my revision notes. Over the semester, students also develop a research proposal through graded milestones, from a question in week three to a full draft and a peer-discussion round in week fourteen, so that the tools of the course culminate in a piece of their own work.

Engagement and Adaptation in the Classroom

Students learn best when they actively apply concepts. I use whiteboard problem-solving to foster reasoning, slides for structure, and in-class experiments to make theory tangible. When teaching supply and demand, I run a live market in which students “buy” and “sell” on private valuations, so that surplus and equilibrium become something they have experienced rather than curves they have seen. I complement lectures with policy debates, group projects, and the occasional film — *A Beautiful Mind* before Nash equilibrium — and I bring current events and new research into the class to show that economics is a living discipline, continuously reshaped by data and ideas.

Technology and AI in Teaching

AI can free students from routine tasks—data cleaning, preliminary literature searches, boilerplate coding—and redirect their energy toward thinking deeply and creatively. In my courses, I integrate AI tools openly and train students to use them responsibly: to brainstorm, draft, and compute, while critically evaluating, refining, and taking ownership of the output. My *Public Finance* syllabus states this policy explicitly and asks students to use AI to study the readings as they would any other resource—and to tell me when it helped. Framed this way, AI is not a shortcut but a catalyst that lowers barriers to entry.

Curricular Innovation and Mentorship

At LUMS, I have incorporated the open-access **CORE** curriculum in introductory courses to make foundational concepts more relatable and globally relevant, and I have designed new behavioral and policy-oriented electives that blend theory, data, and field evidence. I have supervised more than ten undergraduate and master’s theses in development, behavioral, and experimental economics; many of these students have gone on to graduate programs or research assistantships, and I take pride in mentoring them through research design, proposal writing, and professional development.

Teaching Philosophy in Practice

Three principles guide my teaching: **clarity**, **engagement**, and **application**. I begin with intuition before introducing formality; I make learning participatory rather than passive; and I connect classroom knowledge to the societal questions students will face as citizens and professionals. Teaching, for me, is a vocation. The teachers who shaped my own path combined rigor with empathy, and I aim to do the same. Whether a student goes on to graduate school, public service, or a career outside economics, I want them to leave my classes able to reason from evidence, weigh trade-offs, and question assumptions — including my own.